

An online community is just that—a campus. Take your time finding out about all that exists and what activities happen here. Find out about existing members and their likes and dislikes. Know what would be offensive to other members and avoid doing that.

As you spend more time, more members would start noticing you and approaching you... much like it happened in college. There you have your first set of friends. From there on, it's how you take it further.

More on online communities and forums in some of the later chapters.

1.2 IMs For Contacts And Business

Instant Messengers (IMs) have evolved into a communications and business tool. You need to be signed up to use a particular service—for instance, you cannot use Yahoo! Messenger with a Hotmail account and vice-versa. Although there are some IM clients that allow any account to be used, those aren't the best ones.

So there are two options here—sign up for all available IMs, or decide the one you want to use and stick to it. We recommend the first since it costs nothing, and it doesn't hurt to have an ID even if you rarely use it.

IMs are a great tool for communicating with friends, whether they're sitting a few cubicles or a few continents away! Just make sure you match your time with their time zones! IMs also allow you to share files and photos as you chat and play games with the other person. It's as good as being there. To be honest, you are—just that it's virtual.